

set, had over 300 different parts, and used 12 different plastic overlays for the screen. The game sold around a lakh units, but never went on to hit the big league—it went pong!

A game that drew in millions of gaming enthusiasts and that has become institutionalised as one of the biggest hits in the arcade gaming genre, *Pong*, created by Nolan Bushnell, the founder of Atari, brought droves of visitors to gaming arcades in the US and Europe. The game is loosely based around table tennis, and takes an overhead view of the court or table. Atari sold 19,000 *Pong* machines, and imitators soon followed.



Created by Nolan Bushnell, *Pong* was the first gaming sensation

Atari released the Video Computer System, also called the Atari 2600, in 1977. Aimed at the home user, this became the largest-selling console and was the undisputed market leader for a long time.

The Atari 2600, however, wasn't the world's first cartridge-based game console. That would be the Fairchild VES—later renamed the Fairchild Channel F—which was released by Fairchild Semiconductor in 1976.

In the earliest consoles, the code for one or more games was hardcoded into microchips using discrete logic, and no additional games could be added. In the case of cartridge-based games, the programs were burned onto read-only chips. When the cartridges were plugged in, the general-purpose microprocessors in the consoles read the cartridge memory and ran whatever program was stored. Rather than being confined to a